



ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

Lives of Others

So Shah Rukh Khan's life will now be on Discovery Travel and Living for all of us to see as a mini-series. Aamir Khan lets drop nuggets about his smoking habit in his blog. Salman Khan virtually takes us into his life on *Dus ka Dum*, laughing sneakily at his girlfriend for her Hindi or dancing chummily with his brothers. Akshay Kumar is making the second season of *Khatron ka Khiladi* more about himself than about the 13 women. And Amitabh Bachchan is doing a fine job as CEO of the yet-to-be-launched Bachchan News Service. Our appetite for the lives of others is growing steadily. And the others, realising their lives are in the public domain, are choreographing their moves for us. When two actors split up just before a movie they have to promote, is it part of the PR strategy or is it just lurve? When Fiza calls Chander Mohan-turned-Chand Mohammad-turned-Chander Mohan a "mental case", is she promoting her own career in politics or just being a bitter ex? This pornographic obsession will now see us creating new celebrities, who will capture our imagination with their antics. Already, we see evidence of this desperate need for validation not only on TV, but on Facebook, YouTube and Orkut. It's what media scholar Shohini Ghosh calls the staging of personal lives, where you're not anybody if you're not on TV. As Noel Coward said, TV is for appearing on, not looking at.

Which may explain why ordinary people are willing to walk onto a *Sach ka Saamna* set and take on questions about their private lives. Or why a couple have no problems with airing their differences in public on *Aap ki Kacheri*. There are no surveillance cameras, no hidden tapes, no covert wires. It's just a need to be heard, a cry to be seen. Is it because news channels, feeding off the celebrity culture, have brought the notion of stardom so close to the viewer? Nothing is, after all, as democratic as fame. And if it takes a few intrusive questions about your sex life, so

be it. Nine years ago, it took general awareness for an IAS aspirant to become the first crorepati on *Kaun Banega Crorepati*. As we enter a new decade, it will perhaps be awareness of our own lives. As our globe expands, our vision seems to be shrinking. Or maybe we're just new to the cult of the individual and can't get enough of it. Why watch someone else's soap opera, when we can star in our own? Having shunned our earlier Nehruvian attitude to consumerism, it is only a matter of time before we shed our hang-up about sexuality. So we find nothing offensive about watching soaps on TV with our family—90 per cent of homes in India are still single TV homes—even as we find appalling movies such as *Dostana* and *Kambakkht Ishq* hilarious. After all, stars are like us, aren't they? If they can lose their inhibitions on screen, why can't we?

SAURABH SINGH



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Actor **Leela Naidu**, 69, who debuted in 1960 with *Anuradha*, which won her a National Award.



She was crowned Femina Miss India in 1954 and was featured in *Vogue* as one of the world's 10 most beautiful women.

PASSED: By the Gujarat Government, the **Gujarat Control of Organised Crime Bill**, rejecting changes suggested by President Pratibha Patil. The bill makes confessions to a police officer admissible as evidence.

DIED: Malayalam stage and film actor **Rahan P. Dev**, who featured in over 142 Tamil, Kannada and Telugu films. He was 58.

WON: By golfer **Gaganjeet Bhullar**, the Rs 1.92-crore Indonesian President Invitational Cup in Jakarta. He is the youngest Indian to win the event.

